

PARLIAMENT OF ZIMBABWE

Thursday, 26th March, 2026

The National Assembly met at a Quarter-past Two o'clock p.m.

PRAYERS

(THE HON. DEPUTY SPEAKER *in the Chair*)

ANNOUNCEMENTS BY THE HON. DEPUTY SPEAKER

VISITORS IN THE SPEAKER'S GALLERY

THE HON. DEPUTY SPEAKER: I wish to recognise the presence in the Speaker's Gallery, of teachers from Nyabira Primary School. You are welcome. – [HON. MEMBERS: *Hear, hear.*] –
Thank you.

NON-ADVERSE REPORT RECEIVED FROM THE

PARLIAMENTARY LEGAL COMMITTEE

THE HON. DEPUTY SPEAKER: I have to inform the House that I have received a Non-adverse Report from the Parliamentary Legal Committee on the Biological Toxin Weapons Crimes Bill [H. B. 5, 2025].

APPLICATIONS FOR 2026 CONSTITUENCY DEVELOPMENT

FUND

THE HON. DEPUTY SPEAKER: I also have to inform the House that, following the presentation of the 2026 National Budget in December 2025, Treasury has given Parliament the green light to start receiving applications for the Constituency Development Fund for 2026. Hon. Members are encouraged to prioritise all unfinished projects before embarking on new ones. Hon. Members who have not submitted their 2025 acquittals may not access new funding.

HON. MATEWU: Thank you Madam Speaker Ma'am. I rise on a matter of national interest concerning the growing risk facing Zimbabwe's health systems following the withdrawal of external funding supporting HIV and TB programmes. Hundreds of nurses and health workers serving in our Government hospitals under externally funded programmes face job losses on 31 March 2026 as USA support ends. These workers are already carrying the burden of our public health services. Losing them will worsen staff shortages, thereby putting our lives in danger. I urgently call upon the Government to immediately absorb these workers into the national payroll.

Madam Speaker, our HIV and TB stable patients who previously received six months of ARV supplies are now receiving only three months, signaling a declining stop. TB medicines are also reportedly running low, creating a real danger of treatment interruption, drug resistance and preventable deaths.

A recently launched HIV prevention injection, Lenacapavir, is already out of stock since many hospitals, including Epworth Polyclinic, are turning away people who come for the vaccine. These are warning signs of a potential reversal of gains in our fight against HIV and TB. I, therefore, implore the Government to urgently absorb the health workers whose contracts are expiring at the end of March 2026. Procure enough medicines and allow HIV and TB stable patients to revert to their normal six-month routine. I so submit.

HON. MHETU: My point of privilege relates to the point of national interest that I raised seven days ago in this House. I raised the point of national interest on the rapid rise of fuel in this country, which happened last week Wednesday. Part of that request was that the Minister of Energy and Power Development comes to this House to give a Ministerial Statement on the situation with regards to fuel.

We expected that to happen on Tuesday, but today is Thursday. The Minister still has not come to this House to give a Ministerial Statement. In any other jurisdiction, Parliament would be informed of such a rise for whatever reason. I do plead with you Madam Speaker that the Minister comes to this House to give a Ministerial Statement on the situation with regards to fuel in this country. I thank you.

THE HON. DEPUTY SPEAKER: Thank you Hon. Matewu. I have taken note of that.

MOTION

BUSINESS OF THE HOUSE

HON. TOGAREPI: Thank you Madam Speaker. I move that Orders of the Day, Numbers 1 to 4 on today's *Order Paper*, be stood over until Order of the Day Number 5 has been disposed of.

HON. C. MOYO: I second.

Motion put and agreed to.

COMMITTEE STAGE

**RESUMPTION ON CONSIDERATION OF ADVERSE REPORT
BY THE PARLIAMENTARY LEGAL COMMITTEE ON THE
STATE SERVICE (PENSIONS) BILL [H. B. 9, 2024]**

Fifth Order read: Committee: Resumption on the Consideration of the Adverse Report by the Parliamentary Legal Committee on the State Service (Pensions) Bill [H. B. 9, 2024].

House in Committee.

**THE DEPUTY MINISTER OF PUBLIC SERVICE,
LABOUR AND SOCIAL WELFARE (HON. DINHA):** Thank you Mr. Speaker. I rise to respond to the Adverse Report of the Parliamentary Legal Committee on the State Services Pensions Bill. We have already made the amendments which are on page 746 of the *Order Paper*.

On the Long Title, the Long Title does not speak to the doctrine of separation of powers nor infringe it in any way, but it summarises the contents of the Bill. If there is any violation of the doctrine, a request is hereby sought for the Committee to draw our attention to any of the operative or substantive provisions of the Bill which violate that doctrine. It is used for the interpretation of the Bill where there is ambiguity.

Furthermore, the Bill seeks to establish a State Service Pension Fund. The fund will provide for payments of pensions, gratuities and

other benefits in respect of the retirement of persons employed by the State. If the fund is established, all State pension obligations will be met through this fund. So, it is worth noting that the provisions of the Bill do not affect the conditions of service...

HON. MUSHORIWA: On a point of order Hon. Chair. I need to understand what the Hon. Minister is doing. According to Standing Order 144 (4) (b), when there is an Adverse Report, our Standing Orders require that the Minister responsible must be given a reasonable opportunity to respond to the report.

The first thing that we need to hear from the Hon. Minister is to respond to the report tabled by the Parliamentary Legal Committee (PLC) before she actually tells us that she has to accept, saying the Ministry accepts the reasoning profiled by the PLC, which is supposed to be the first entry. Once she does that, she then goes on to say other things. Right now, we are lost. She is supposed to respond to the report of the PLC, which is what our Standing Order says. I thank you.

THE TEMPORARY CHAIRPERSON (HON. J. TSHUMA):

The Chair had also advised the Hon. Minister to do exactly that. So, I was of the notion that maybe she was going to end with that issue.

Hon. Minister, as we discussed here, you need to respond to the report on your position as a Ministry.

HON. DINHA: Thank you Mr. Speaker. The Ministry agrees with the issues raised by the Parliamentary Legal Committee. We have made amendments which are on page 746 of the *Order Paper*.

HON. MUSHORIWA: We acknowledge the Hon. Minister's acceptance of the PLC's findings and the subsequent amendments presented on the *Order Paper*. This House relies on the PLC to advise us on whether these proposed amendments meet constitutional standards.

In our view, it is crucial to hear from the PLC regarding the constitutional validity of these amendments. Given that the PLC has passed an Adverse Report and the Ministry has conceded to it, we seek clarity on whether the proposed amendments align with constitutional provisions.

This guidance is essential for our decision-making process as our Standing Orders mandate that we accept the PLC's report. The PLC is tasked with advising this House on whether the proposed amendments, if enacted, would effectively align the Bill with constitutional requirements.

To that end, Hon. Chair, I would appreciate a response from the PLC as it will provide us with the necessary direction for our debate. Thank you.

HON. ZVOBGO: My understanding is that the Minister has withdrawn the Bill by accepting that the PLC was correct, the Minister has in fact, firstly withdrawn...

THE TEMPORARY CHAIRPERSON: Order! Let me have a bit of consultation. Please approach the desk there. Thank you.

Hon. Zvobgo having been asked to approach the table.

**THE DEPUTY MINISTER OF PUBLIC SERVICE,
LABOUR AND SOCIAL WELFARE (HON. DINHA):** Thank you Mr. Speaker. I move that we report progress and seek leave to sit again.

House resumed.

Progress reported.

Committee to resume: Tuesday, 7th April, 2026.

MOTION

BUSINESS OF THE HOUSE

HON. TOGAREPI: Madam Speaker, I move that Orders of the Day, Numbers 6 to 18 be stood over until Order of the Day Number 19 has been disposed of.

HON. NYANDORO: I second.

Motion put and agreed to.

MOTION

USE OF AI IN THE SHORTLISTING AND RECRUITMENT OF STUDENT NURSES AND STUDENT TEACHERS

HON. BAJILA: I move the motion standing in my name that
this that this House;

NOTING the demand for nursing and teacher training places in
Zimbabwe far exceeds available spaces;

CONCERNED that existing manual shortlisting processes are
prone to delays, inconsistencies and a lack of transparency;

AWARE that Artificial intelligence (AI) can enhance efficiency, fairness, and merit-based selection when properly regulated;

MINDFUL of the Government's commitment to digital transformation and innovation;

NOW, THEREFORE, resolves that Ministries of Information Communication Technology, Postal and Courier Services; Primary and Secondary Education, and Health and Child Care, pilot the use of AI in the shortlisting and recruitment of student nurses and student teachers.

HON. HAMAUSWA: I second.

HON. BAJILA: Madam Speaker, I rise to move this motion on the adoption of Artificial intelligence-assisted systems in the recruitment and shortlisting of student nurses and student teachers in Zimbabwe, a matter that sits at the intersection of equity, integrity and national development. There are moments when the credibility of public systems must be confronted with candour and ornament. The recruitment of student nurses and trainee teachers is one such moment. It is a process that determines, not only who is trained but ultimately, who will stand at the frontline of our healthcare and

education system and be trusted with the lives and dignity of our people.

Yet, in a context where applications far outstrip available training spaces, the integrity of this process becomes both a moral obligation and a matter of national consequence. It must be beyond reproach, defensible and above all, must be anchored in merit. At the core of this motion, is the need to firmly cement the integrity and credibility of recruitment processes into both student nurses and teacher training institutions in Zimbabwe. The demand for training in these critical public service professions has grown markedly over the years, driven by a combination of sectors, including expanding healthcare needs, increasing enrolment pressures within the education sector, demographic shifts and the sustained global demand for Zimbabwean-trained professionals.

At the same time, training institutions continue to operate within finite capacity, constrained by infrastructure, teaching personnel and fiscal limitations. The result is a widening disparity between the number of qualified applicants and the limited space available for training across both sectors. This imbalance in effect

transformed what ought to be a routine administrative exercise into a high-stakes and intensively competitive process. Each application cycle now carries significant consequences not only for the individuals involved, but for the broader health and education systems that depend on the calibre of those selected.

In such a context, the shortlisting process ceases to be a mere procedural step. It becomes the decisive gateway through which merit must be rigorously assessed, safeguarded and seen to prevail across both nursing and teacher training pathways. It is precisely because of this pressure that any perceived opacity or inconsistency invites legitimate concern where demand is higher and opportunity is scarce. Even marginal weaknesses in the system can be exploited thereby undermining fairness and eroding public confidence. What is therefore required is not only efficiency but a system that is demonstrably credible, resilient and insulated from undue influence.

Madam Speaker, the scale of imbalance is neither abstract nor anecdotal. It is stark and quantifiable. Zimbabwe records in excess of 100 000 applications for nurse training manually, yet available training capacity remains limited to approximately 1 200. In effect,

fewer than one in every 100 applicants secure admission. At the level of individual institutions, the disparity is even more pronounced.

Major central hospitals routinely receive between 5 000 and 8 000 applications per intake but admit fewer than 100 trainees per cycle while smaller training schools often enroll as few as 15 to 20 students.

This pattern is not confined to the health sector. With teacher training, a similarly constrained pipeline persists. Zimbabwe's education system employs over 150 000 teachers, yet teacher training colleges limited in number and capacity, typically enroll only a few hundred students per institution across their respective intakes.

Consequently, thousands of aspiring educators compete annually for a relatively small number of training opportunities, reinforcing a system where demand consistently outstrips supply.

These figures are not merely descriptive, they are dispositive. They reveal a system under a sustained pressure where access is scarce and competition is intense. In such an environment, even the slightest compromise in the integrity of the selection process ceases to be a minor administrative flaw. It becomes a profound injustice with far-reaching implications for both public trust and service delivery. It

is precisely within such a constrained and high-pressure environment that systemic vulnerabilities have begun to crystalise into something far more troubling.

Recent developments have exposed not isolated lapses, but a pattern of irregularity within the recruitment of student nurses that calls for urgent and decisive intervention. Investigations by the Zimbabwe Anti-Corruption Commission have brought to light serious allegations in institutions such as Chinhoyi Provincial Hospital where officials responsible for recruitment were accused of soliciting bribes, manipulating short-listing processes and even leaking interview questions to preferred candidates ahead of assessment.

Further, evidence emerging from the investigations points to a deeply concerning commodification of opportunity where prospective students have reportedly been required to pay between USD1 200 and USD1 500 in order to secure training placement, effectively transforming access to public training institutions into a transactional exercise rather than a merit-based one.

In addition, cases involving the use of fraudulent academic qualifications have been reported, exposing critical weaknesses in

verification systems and institutional oversight. These developments are compounded by long-standing concerns around nepotism and favouritism where selection outcomes are influenced by personal connections, thereby reducing formal recruitment processes to little more than procedural formalities. What emerges from this body of evidence is a system that under sustained pressure has become susceptible to manipulation at multiple levels, from short-listing and interviews to final administrations.

In such a context, merit ceases to be the primary determinant of opportunity and is instead diluted by financial capacity and access to persons responsible. This is not merely administrative failure. It is a systemic distortion of far-reaching implications. When recruitment into a profession as critical as nursing is compromised, the consequences extend beyond questions of fairness into the very fabric of public service delivery. The erosion of standards at the point of entry inevitably affects the quality of training, the competence of graduates and ultimately, the standard of care delivered to our beloved citizens, thereby undermining public confidence in both institutions and the outcomes therein.

What we are witnessing is not simply administrative weakness, but a clear deviation from the constitutional and statutory principles that are meant to anchor fairness, transparency and accountability within our public institutions. The Constitution of Zimbabwe provides an unambiguous standard against which such practices must be measured. Section 56 of our Constitution guarantees equality and non-discrimination, affirming that every person has the right to equal protection and benefit of the law.

In the context of recruitment into critical public service professions such as nursing and teaching, this provision requires that access to training opportunities be determined strictly on the basis of merit without undue influence arising from financial capacity, personal connections and extraneous considerations.

Further, Section 68 of our beloved Constitution entrenches the right to fair and administrative justice, ensuring that every person is entitled to lawful, reasonable and procedural administrative conduct. A recruitment system that is opaque, inconsistent or susceptible to manipulation stands in direct contradiction to this constitutional guarantee. Complementing this is Section 194, which sets out the

basic values and principles guiding public administration, including transparency, accountability, efficiency and the requirement that public institutions be conducted in a manner that inspires public confidence. Recruitment processes for both nursing and teacher training institutions fall squarely within the ambit of these obligations.

Beyond the Constitution, statutory frameworks such as the Public Service Act, [*Chapter* 16:04], particularly Section 18, governs the appointments within the Public Service. This section underscores the importance of merit, suitability and adherence to established procedural measures. This is reinforced by the broader mandate of the Public Service Commission under Section 3, to ensure proper administration and integrity across public institutions.

Taken together, these provisions establish a clear legal imperative that recruitment into both nursing and teaching pipelines must be conducted in a manner that is equitable, transparent, and beyond reproach. Any system that falls short of this standard is not merely inefficient, it is constitutionally deficient. It is against this backdrop that this motion proposes a deliberate framework and forward-looking intervention, which is the adoption of Artificial

intelligence-based systems in shortlisting and recruitment of student nurses. The intervention of this intention is neither to displace human judgement nor mechanise a fundamentally human process but rather, to strengthen it by introducing systems that are consistent, transparent and resistant to manipulation.

Artificial intelligence has the capacity to process large volumes of applications within a level of uniformity that manual systems cannot reliably sustain, applying preferred criteria such as academic performance, subject combinations and eligibility requirements in a manner that is both systemic and auditable. In practical terms, such systems can ensure that every application is assessed against the same objective standard, thereby minimising discretion at initial stages of recruitment where vulnerabilities are most pronounced. They can also incorporate verification mechanisms that flag inconsistencies in subject qualifications, reducing risk of fraudulent entry into training programmes.

In doing so, Artificial intelligence does not eliminate human oversight. Rather, it repositions it to a higher level of review and accountability where decisions can be interrogated against a

transparent and traceable system. The proposition before this House is neither novel nor experimental in the global context. It is aligned with an emerging trajectory in public administration and education systems worldwide. In India for instance, Universal AI University has implemented an AI-driven admissions system that automates candidate screening, conducts virtual interviews and evaluates applications using standardised digital criteria, significantly reducing human interference while improving efficiency and transparency.

Similarly, countries such as Brazil and Estonia have moved to integrate artificial intelligence into public systems, not only to enhance service delivery but also to detect anomalies, reduce fraud and improve decision-making within large, scalable administrative processes. In Brazil, the National AI Plan explicitly incorporates AI tools to identify irregularities in public systems and optimise administrative decision-making, demonstrating how technology can be leveraged to strengthen institutional integrity. While the potential benefits of AI in strengthening recruitment systems are evident, its adoption must be approached with deliberate caution and a clear ethical framework.

The introduction of such technology into public decision-making raises legitimate concerns around data privacy, algorithmic bias and accountability, all of which must be proactively addressed to ensure that the system enhances rather than undermine fairness.

Therefore, Artificial intelligence systems are only as reliable as the data and the criteria upon which they are built and without proper safeguards, there is a risk that existing inequalities may be inadvertently reproduced within automated processes. It is for this reason that international best practices, including guidance from UNESCO on Artificial intelligence in education and public systems, emphasise the principles of transparency, explainability and human oversight.

Any AI-assisted recruitment system must be designed in such a way that its decision-making process can be interrogated, understood where necessary and challenged. This ensures that the system does not become a black box but rather, a transparent tool that supports accountable governance. What therefore emerges is not merely a case for technological adoption, but a compelling argument for systemic reform anchored in integrity, efficiency and fairness.

The introduction of AI-assisted shortlisting systems presents an opportunity to decisively confront long-standing weaknesses within our recruitment processes while aligning Zimbabwe with contemporary approaches to public administration. It offers a pathway through which merit can be safeguarded, processes can be standardised and institutional credibility can be restored in a manner that is both practical and sustainable.

This House is therefore presented with a clear and reasoned choice to retain a system that has shown susceptibility to manipulation or to take a deliberate step towards strengthening it through innovation that is both guided and accountable. The adoption of AI, in this context, is not an abstract aspiration. It is a pragmatic response to a clearly defined challenge, one that speaks directly to the principles of equity, transparency and excellence that we seek to uphold as a country.

As we bring this matter to a close, it is instructive to reflect on the position already articulated within this very institution of Parliament. The Hon. Speaker of Parliament, Advocate J. F. N. Mudenda, speaking at the 57th Plenary Assembly Session of the

SADC Parliamentary Forum in the mighty Victoria Falls, emphasised that, “Artificial intelligence is now a reality of life, whether we like it or not”. He further underscored the need for legislative frameworks to guide its response for adoption and advancing national development.

The recognition is therefore both timely and profound. It underscores the fact that the question before us is no longer, whether Artificial intelligence will be integrated into our systems or not, but how deliberately, responsibly and effectively we choose to harness it.

In this regard, the proposal to adopt AI-assisted recruitment in the selection of student nurses and trainee teachers is fully aligned with the National Vision 1 that embraces innovation and technology as a vehicle for transparency, efficiency and inclusive development. In embracing this motion, this House will not merely be responding to a present challenge but will be at the forefront of a transformative shift in public administration. We will be affirming that merit must prevail over manipulation, that systems must inspire confidence and that technology, when guided by principle, can serve as a powerful instrument of justice. I so submit.

HON. HAMAUSWA: Thank you Madam Speaker, for giving me this opportunity to second a motion eloquently moved by Hon. Bajila, giving a candid expose' of the current weaknesses characterising the recruitment systems that are being used to recruit teachers and nurses in our country. This is not only a timely motion, but it is also a necessary one because, as Hon. Bajila highlighted, Artificial intelligence is now the way of life that is actually shaping and influencing the way we do business.

The issues raised are neither speculative nor peripheral. They go to the very heart of how this nation allocates opportunities within two of its most critical public service professions, that is, teaching and nursing. This motion identifies a structural weakness that has persisted over time. There have been a lot of concerns raised by the citizens of Zimbabwe who allege that in the recruitment of teachers and nurses, there is a lot of corruption and nepotism. In the end, the system has been described as something that is not fair.

The allocation of training opportunities in these sectors is increasingly under strain. As the number of applicants continues to grow, it is far outpacing the capacity of training institutions. So, in

such an environment, the integrity of the shortlisting process becomes paramount. Therefore, fairness must be demonstrated, not assumed. It must be seen, done and it must not just be heard, but fairness must be seen to be happening in the recruitment of these two critical professions.

However, as has already been articulated, reliance on largely manual systems has exposed the process to inconsistencies and in some instances, manipulation. Where discretion is broad and systems are insufficiently standardised, there is a risk of bias, favouritism and even outright corruption that maybe difficult to contain. This is not merely an administrative inconvenience, it is actually a distortion of opportunity and undermines public confidence and compromises the calibre of those entering professions that are central to national development.

It is interesting to note that Artificial intelligence-based recruitment systems are faster and also smarter in the way they reduce the current weaknesses that we have witnessed in our country. AI recruitment systems can work 24/7, which is an advantage. The tools can use an intelligent agent that can conduct interviews 24/7, around

the clock without any challenges. This is where this country should be going. In 2026, there are around 18 top AI tools that are being used in HR and also for recruitment purposes. For example, the Paradox, HireVue, JuiceBox and SeekOut. All these tools can be applied and enhance recruitment and bring the much-needed confidence in the recruitment systems.

This system can also be applied into other public service professions and can even be adopted by the private sector because it enhances the recruitment processes and eliminates some of the challenges that are being faced. It is precisely for this reason, Madam Speaker, that the proposal to integrate Artificial intelligence-assisted systems deserves serious consideration. Such systems offer the possibility of introducing uniformity, traceability and objectivity to the initial stages of recruitment.

There is something that is also done by Artificial intelligence tools, which is important. They can pick and fish out what candidates post on their social media platforms. This can be used to see the suitability of someone to be recruited into nursing or into a teaching profession. Why is it necessary to check what prospective candidates

post on their social media platforms? It reflects their culture. It reflects their behaviour, even towards maybe gender equality and other critical issues that are really important.

When you apply these Artificial intelligence tools, they really enhance the quality of the candidates that are going to be recruited. Zimbabwe, therefore, stands at a point where it can draw from some of the experiences that have adopted AI tools in the HR departments. This is good to also see what other countries are actually doing in other universities across the world. They are already teaching or having courses where artificial intelligence tools are being integrated into HR systems. I submit Madam Speaker that this is the right time that the Zimbabwean Government think through and rethink how AI can be integrated into our HR systems and all other related systems.

It is also important to emphasise that the adoption of such systems must be guided by clear ethical and regulatory frameworks. It is our hope that this Parliament is going to come up with or to engage with the Executive to make sure that the regulatory frameworks are in place such that AI tool is going to promote development. It will not be viewed as something that is anathema to development, but something

that enhances development and something that will not bring more harm than the expected benefits. Issues of data protection are also important to consider when we are going to adopt this AI and its related tools for recruitment purposes.

This motion, as I said, ultimately advances technology, not just for its own sake but for the restoration of trust in the public processes. As I said, the trust in the recruitment processes last week in this House, there were concerns. A question was raised on the recruitment of soldiers in our country and the fears were allayed by the Minister of Defence but still because people are complaining, this is the tool that is coming at the right time to make sure that there is restoration of public trust in the recruitment of the public in the public service. It is about ensuring that access to training in both nursing and teaching is determined by merit, integrity and fairness. These values are consistent, as Hon. Bajila has said, with our constitutional principles and our national aspirations.

I also strongly believe that the adoption of this tool is in line with the National Artificial intelligence Strategy that was launched last week. This tool seeks to take advantage of AI tools, such as

maybe adopting methods like automation. I think this is in line with national aspirations...

THE HON. DEPUTY SPEAKER: Hon. Members, may we lower our voices?

HON. HAMAUSWA: As I conclude Madam Speaker, in my support of this motion, I strongly believe that there is a need to put the systems in place to make sure that everything that is needed from regulatory and in terms also of training, is put in place, to make sure that our universities will also come up with our home-grown systems that are artificial intelligence-based to support government initiatives. This tool, I am sure Madam Speaker, is going to be celebrated in our country. Thank you.

***HON. MAPIKI:** Thank you for the opportunity to debate this very important motion that was brought in by Hon. Bajila. I am in support of this motion. I think each province should be given a quota when it comes to recruitment of nurses and teachers so that we will be able to account for the process. If we use AI in applying for jobs, it curbs these issues of taking bribes because nobody will be able to know the individuals. This also reduces the incidences of some found

in possession of wrong certificates. Like what was proposed in this House, that DNA tests should be conducted before applying for a child's birth certificate, similarly, when one is applying for a job, the certificate must be verified to see if that certificate is the right one.

I also think that Artificial intelligence should be used when recruiting teachers because some wait for years before they are called for the job yet some only take days because they are connected to people that can quicken their recruitment. This is also causing abuse in our girl children because they will be forced to fall in love with those people in order for them to get employed, like what Matavire said in his song '*tanga wandida*'. So, if AI is used in these recruitments, nobody will be able to know who is who.

Again, if it is used when marking exams in colleges, the issue of abuse on students will be minimised. When we visited universities, most students were complaining that the teachers or lecturers also sing the same song "*tanga wandida*" so that you get good grades. This will also help to identify the best students rather than when a third party is involved in marking and favouring their own.

Zimbabwe is lagging behind when it comes to AI because countries like Japan, South Korea and other developed countries are now using Artificial intelligence. We should have platforms like what ECONET is using, so I think we should take AI seriously to cover a lot of things.

The issue of corruption has become rampant in the recruitment of nurses and teachers. They are now taking advantage of people's desperation and use that to make money. Those in offices say *mbudzi inodya payakasungirirwa*. In my constituency, many are crying because of the money being charged for them to be on the waiting list. They are asked to pay \$400 or \$1000. Most of the times they end up not included in the waiting list. Same applies to teacher recruitment.

I think this problem is caused by shortage of training centres. In Ghana, in each province, you find four or five training centres and this will ease pressure on one training centre. So, I suggest that each province must have four training centres. I do not know why we are failing to have such scenarios. In Mashonaland Central, there is one, Madziva Teachers College, which is a primary training college even though the universities are helping. So, you will find that those who

want to train in secondary will have to go to Belvedere Teachers' College and others. I think Government should have a policy just like the one we have in building schools, such that we also build training centres in provinces and even to cascade the project down to district level. For example, Shamva Hospital should be allowed to train people in their district.

I urge all the ministries to try and use AI. When I went to Japan, I saw old people being monitored with drones. In China, they were saying they now have 36 000 drones which harvest fruits. I thank you Hon. Bajila for this motion and I support it.

HON. MAVHUDZI: Thank you Madam Speaker Ma'am. I want to thank you for the opportunity to also add my voice in support of the motion tabled by Hon. Bajila and seconded by Hon. Hamauswa, a motion that speaks to the adoption of Artificial Intelligence (AI) in shortlisting of student nurses and teachers in Zimbabwe. This is a very important motion which speaks to pertinent issues critical in addressing the confusion and the rot that we have witnessed in the nurses' recruitment system in the country.

Madam Speaker, let us be honest about the state of our recruitment system. Every year, thousands of young Zimbabweans queue at the doorsteps of our nursing schools and teacher training colleges to apply. Most of them are denied, not on merit but because of the rot in the system.

Madam Speaker, the demand for places for teacher education and nurse training far exceeds the supply. Yet, the system we rely on to shortlist candidates is archaic, retrograded and a relic of the past. It is a manual process, slow, laborious and prone to human error. A qualified candidate can easily be overlooked, lost in a sea of paperwork, or unfairly judged due to subjective bias. Such inefficiency fosters the “*unoziva ani*” syndrome where only those connected to individuals in the corridors of power gain admission whilst the down-trodden talented young men and women are relegated to the dustbins of demise. This anathema Madam Speaker, demoralises our youth and undermines the meritocracy of our Constitution.

At the core of this motion Madam Speaker, is the idea of fairness which has been elaborated unequivocally by Hon Bajila, Hon

Mapiki and Hon. Hamauswa who debated before me. Madam Speaker, AI removes bias, fatigue and the influence of personal connections. The student who has worked hard, studied diligently and meets all the criteria must be shortlisted, not the one with connections. This gives every applicant an equal chance. We must restore public confidence in our recruitment processes and the only way we can do it, at this moment, is through the use of AI.

Madam Speaker, the introduction of AI is not about replacing humans, it is about augmenting our capacity and fairness of the system. The use of AI will enhance objectivity, reduce bias, clientelism and corruption, maladies which have since become the order of the day in the teacher training institutions and the nursing schools alike. This initiative Madam Speaker, as it reduces human interface with the recruitment system, also augments the fairness of the process. An AI algorithm does not have a relative, an automated process cares less about cousins, an intelligent system is not gullible to neighbours. It examines grades, subjects, prerequisites with clinical impartiality, ensuring that the best candidates rise on merit alone. It is important to note that the use of AI in the selection process is by no

means the replacement of humans, and this must be emphasised. AI handles the administrative tasks of shortlisting. Interviews and assessments are done by the staff as has always been happening.

Madam Speaker Ma'am, the speed with which these applications are processed will be increased as well. Upon submitting applications, prospective students are forced to wait for months before receiving responses from these institutions. As a matter of fact, even after having been rejected, applicants usually do not receive any correspondence from the respective institutions. What takes a Committee three weeks to process can be completed in mere minutes by AI or a Chatbot.

The use of AI also fosters geographical fairness in the selection process. By digitising the process, a child in Chiendambuya, Binga, Chipinge or Malipati, can also have an equal opportunity as a child in Harare. No region, no district or community can be disadvantaged. A child in the most remote area in Zimbabwe will not spend their last ZiG notes on bus fare to a few nursing schools or teacher training centres just to drop off a form. An AI can do that in seconds *via* a mobile portal. The use of AI in this process Madam Speaker, also

engenders digital inclusion. We have a lot of ICT centres in every district in this country. They can then also assist in making this process a bit more efficient.

Madam Speaker, there are several countries that have been using this system in hiring and streamlining the recruitment process. Countries like South Africa, Kenya and Mauritius have also been using this system. It has proven that it is an efficient system.

As I conclude Madam Speaker, if we wish to achieve the aspirations of National Development Strategy 2, we have to revolutionise our recruitment processes. AI is a tool of fairness, efficiency and equity. It strengthens institutions and empowers youths. It restores faith in public recruitment. I so submit. I thank you Madam Speaker.

HON. CHIDUWA: Thank you Madam Speaker. I rise to support the motion that has been moved by Hon. Bajila, which calls for the use of Artificial Intelligence in the shortlisting and recruitment of teachers and nurses in Zimbabwe.

Madam Speaker Ma'am, the motion is both timely and progressive. What we are looking at is not the replacement of human beings with machines but rather, the motion seeks to ensure that technology is used to make our recruitment systems more efficient, transparent and fair. In Zimbabwe, Madam Speaker Ma'am, nurses and teachers are the backbone of our health and education sector. If we recruit the nurses and teachers slowly, unfairly and inefficiently, the consequences are going to be serious. These consequences, we will see them in the products that we will witness as we move around and we will also see them when we look at the health of our country.

In hospitals, if the recruitment is not done timely, they will remain understaffed. Schools will remain without qualified teachers or they will also remain understaffed. Rural communities will not be served well and this is going to move against the spirit of inclusivity, where under vision 2030 we say every place should be covered.

So, what does artificial intelligence mean for us, especially when we are looking at recruitment? When applications are received, these applications are sorted in time. Imagine what the mover of the motion said when he said we receive up to 20 000 applications and if

these applications are sorted manually, it will take months, if not years. The use of artificial intelligence is going to assist us in the sorting and grading of applications. Artificial intelligence is also very critical when it comes to checking qualifications and professional requirements and this again is something that can be done expeditiously.

We are looking at the shortlisting of candidates, which is also going to be done faster, given that once the shortlisting algorithms are set, the artificial intelligence will just do it for us. The ranking of applications is also going to be done by artificial intelligence. We have heard other debaters mentioning critically that artificial intelligence knows no relatives, artificial intelligence knows no brothers and with artificial intelligence, this is going to assist us, especially when it comes to the ranking of applicants using the algorithm which would have been set. artificial intelligence can also assist when it comes to the detection of incomplete applications. You can imagine one would have submitted applications, only for one to realise that the application was incomplete. Nevertheless, if applications are submitted with the guidance of artificial intelligence

this is going to assist in quickly detecting applications that are incomplete.

So, as we move forward, how is this going to assist us? With regards to speed and efficiency, I have already alluded to this where the manual system is going to take time. artificial intelligence also assists us when it comes to merit-based recruitment. We have seen in the media where nurses, prospective teachers have gone for training, only to be discovered maybe one year or two years after the training has already commenced that their qualifications were fake.

We are saying this can also be assisted when it comes to artificial intelligence. Then the issue of rural staffing shortages. We have seen nurses and teachers who have deliberately indicated that they would want to practice in rural areas. When you have got a heap of applications going above 20 000, manually sifting through applications of more than 20 000 is not an easy task. Once this is subjected to go through artificial intelligence, this is going to assist in identifying applicants who would want to work in rural areas. This is going to assist us especially when it comes to the implementation of

Government policy of inclusivity and ensuring that no place is going to be left behind.

Issues of transparency have been mentioned already but again this is a very critical issue. We have ZACC and we have institutions that are meant to promote efficiency and ensuring that there is no bias when it comes to recruitment. This is going to assist especially on transparency.

As I conclude Madam Speaker Ma'am, there are a number of issues where concerns are likely to be raised on the issue of bias. The algorithms of artificial intelligence, they can also be set in a way that it can actually create bias. One would want to make sure that as we come up with artificial intelligence, as we build up the system, it should also be done by people who are transparent because at the end of the day, the Artificial Intelligence can actually be set in a way that is going to be biased.

We want to make sure that as we embrace artificial intelligence, let it be done by people who are of high standing. We are also looking at issues to do with addressing agent problems. In as much as artificial intelligence is going to assist, human factor is still needed when it

comes to compassionate cases. I would want to give you an example where even at personal level, I have observed one or two people from my constituency, people of humble backgrounds. They have been assisted by well-wishers to go to school. They are staying with a grandmother who is disabled and when we have got such a case that requires a compassionate approach, we have gone to the Public Service Commission to say, we have got this case where we would want you to consider on compassionate grounds.

Also, where we are using artificial intelligence, it may not have that compassion. So, as much as we use artificial intelligence, we also want to make sure that the human component is going to remain embedded.

As I conclude, I would want to support the motion by Hon. Bajila, which speaks to the transformation that we are going through as a country. If you check our NDS 2 coming from NDS 1, transformation, the use of digitilisation in making decisions is in the forefront and artificial intelligence is one such, which is part of the digitisation agenda of this country.

I fully support the motion by Hon. Bajila but as we adopt the motion, we also need to take into account that the human factor should still remain embedded in the artificial intelligence, because where we have got cases like the one I mentioned, where there is need for compassionate considerations, we would need the human factor otherwise, I support the motion by Hon. Bajila. I so submit.

*** HON. MAKUMIRE:** Thank you Madam Speaker for giving me this opportunity to air my opinion on this important motion that was raised by Hon. Bajila. The issue that is being raised here is an issue that shows difficulties for one to be recruited in the nursing school and teacher's college. As has been highlighted, there are many people who want to be recruited but the vacancies are few. We know that every time that something is wanted by everyone but it is limited, the end is not good. We see that it has opened gaps for corruption. Nursing school vacancies are offered to only those who have money, those who come from the same village, same totem or relatives who are into politics. That has affected both nursing schools and teaching colleges.

If you look at the bribes that are paid for one to get a place in a nursing school or teacher's college, it is an amount that one needs to work for the whole year. That shows that as a Government, there is something that we have failed to correct that has led us to where we are. This motion has brought a very good issue that this problem that we are facing is being created by people who are in high offices. This is caused by people who influence decisions. The ICT together with AI, assist that a person's mind and human input is limited pertaining to the issue of recruitment. I am supporting this motion because it assists that everything goes through ICT or AI.

This AI programme formulates waiting lists that we follow, that if everyone qualifies, it also assists in grading. You would notice that there is someone who had completed the diploma course 10 years ago, but has not secured a place, not that the person does not qualify but he or she does not have money to pay for the bribe or does not have a connection with a councillor or someone involved in politics who can link him. This has made people with passion in nursing to be left out because they do not have money.

When the economy was stable, these jobs were taken by people who had passion but now everyone is going there because there are no jobs. So, limited places in nursing should not be filled by greedy people who want to benefit taking advantage of the state of the country. The AI programme is delaying us, if it can be fast-tracked that next year or even this year, we incorporate that the Government has the database that is managed by AI. The person who was the last to apply will be the first to be considered.

AI is good for us as a country because everyone will embrace it and it is a very good programme. I wish if Ministers involved in this issue were present so that we enlighten them on this matter. We are seeing it as a good thing. Most of our students are now going to Zambia, working there, assisting those countries and yet our country is lagging behind. So, Hon. Speaker Ma'am, I am supporting this motion. Thank you.

HON. MAZHINDU: Thank you Madam Speaker. I rise to support this progressive motion in a forward-looking way. Firstly, the motion correctly notes that the demand for nursing and teacher training places in Zimbabwe far exceeds available spaces. Every year,

thousands of qualified young Zimbabweans apply, yet only a fraction is admitted. This creates frustration, suspicion and in some cases, allegations of unfairness. While opportunity is limited, the selection process must be beyond reproach.

Secondly, the manual shortlisting systems are indeed prone to delays, inconsistencies and lack of transparency. Human systems, no matter how well-intentioned, are vulnerable to error, fatigue, bias and sometimes undue influence. In critical sectors such as health and education where merit, competence and direct self-delivery cannot afford inefficiencies, the motion does not propose replacing human judgement with machines. It proposes piloting Artificial Intelligence as a tool, a regulated, supervised system to enhance efficiency, fairness and merit-driven selection. When properly designed, AI can process thousands of applications in minutes, apply consistent criteria uniformly to all candidates, reduce human bias and eliminate favouritism, generate auditable records and enhance accountability, and improve transparency through clear scoring and mechanisms. Zimbabwe has already committed itself to digital transformation. If we are serious about innovation, we must be prepared to modernise

our administrative systems, especially in high-demand public institutions.

Constituencies in urban areas have capable students who are sometimes disadvantaged by opaque systems. A properly regulated AI pilot would live within the playing field, ensuring that selection is based on qualifications, performance and defined criteria. Of course, the Government must put in place a clear regulatory oversight, protection of personal data, periodic audits of algorithms, and human reviews for appeals.

This is why the motion proposes a pilot programme, not a wholesale replacement. A pilot allows us to test, evaluate and refine before full implementation. If we modernise our selection systems in teacher and nurse training, we strengthen the very foundation of our nation, education and healthcare. Innovation is not a threat to governance. It is an instrument to improve governance. Let us embrace technology responsibly and ensure that opportunities in Zimbabwe are streamlined by merit, not by money or inefficiencies. I thank you.

HON. CHIGUMBU: Thank you Hon. Speaker. It is my pleasure to contribute to this very important motion. I have been listening to the presenters who have been debating this motion. I think they have been doing their best to emphasise how important AI can be in a society. However, I would like to point out that although AI is a very useful tool, AI cannot be referred to as a magic wand that cures a broken culture. I want to applaud Hon. Bajila for bringing up this motion. However, I would like to debate in a way that I will offer some amendments to the prayers that he has been raising in his motion saying that, do we need artificial intelligence to fix our broken culture? Do we need technology to fix our broken culture? I do not think that is the case. AI has never been meant to fix a broken culture. AI has been meant to be used as a tool to amplify progress. If you are to wake up today and say we want to come up with an AI solution for recruitment, the first thing that we must ask ourselves is, why are we having this problem in the first place? Is the problem a result of a lack of technology or is it a result of a certain culture that has been embedded in our society?

Mr. Speaker, we can come up with the best AI solution today, but if we do not fix the right problem, that intervention will not be of any use. There are systems that are there that are being used for the very same purpose that we want AI to address. My point, as I was hearing others debating, they were saying AI is going to be used to make sure that it streamlines applications, but that can easily be done by knowledge and expert systems. What they are simply saying is, we want a person who has got five 'O' levels to be shortlisted through a sort of software intervention. There are systems that are there that can just follow simple logic, 'if - else logic'. If a student applies and has five 'O' levels, allow him to progress with the application, block the student from progressing. These are very simple systems out there that we can use. These systems are tried and tested.

The issue with AI is that it is still an experimental technology. The issue with AI is that it carries certain biases. So, if we sit today and debate to say we want these systems to be adopted for recruitment, we have a problem. If a child is discriminated against by this very system, how are they going to seek recourse? We do not have laws that address the issues of biases that come through the use

of AI. So, before we talk about AI, there are things that need to be fixed.

I think the major problem that has led Hon. Bajila to pen this motion is a decay in culture. The problem is that we have inculcated a culture whereby we no longer believe in meritocracy as a nation. We are people who now do things based on who you know and who you do not know. I have overheard some Hon. Members having conversations. What they were saying, the time for these institutions to enrol students has come. I am going to talk with the Minister so that he can enrol five students from my constituency. Some of them will be using their political party positions to force those who enroll or those who lead the enrolment process to take students that come from their constituencies or from their political parties. So, what we need is to fix the broken culture.

Then when it comes to technology, I concur with Hon. Bajila that we definitely need a technological intervention when it comes to enrolment. I also have to define a bit. This has to be a whole of Government approach. You cannot have a piecemeal solution to this problem. So, what we need is a proper recruitment platform for all...

THE TEMPORARY SPEAKER (HON. J. TSHUMA): You mentioned that you heard Hon. Members asking the Minister to enrol five of the people from their constituencies and their parties. The moment you say such kind of a statement, you need to substantiate it with hard evidence because that now becomes an allegation. In this House, we do not want to operate like that. So, I think that if you are not in a position to say who they are, maybe just withdraw that statement and carry on with your fine debate. We do not want to put allegations on any Hon. Member here.

HON. CHIGUMBU: I did not say they told me. I said I overheard them making such statements. The point that I am trying to drive at is that the culture is what is broken Hon. Speaker.

THE TEMPORARY SPEAKER: Order, order! That is exactly what I am saying. If you overheard, it means you saw them, so you know them. Are you in a position to name them?

HON. CHIGUMBU: I can rephrase, but the point that I want to make is, the problem that you are having is not a software problem. The problem is the broken culture. We all know that when the time comes, most of the people in this House, when they want votes, abuse

the system to make sure that their people are enrolled in those institutions without following proper procedures. So, the problem is not about the software. The problem is about the broken culture. That is the point that I am trying to drive. I gave an example of what I came across as a Member of Parliament. There are such kind of talks amongst ourselves where people say I have got five of my students who want to be enrolled and I will have to talk to the Minister. Yet the process might be like this, the ministry should just open up for students to enrol and they are supposed to enrol without any assistance from any political powerhouse. That is the point that I am driving Hon. Speaker. Thank you so much.

The other thing that I also want to emphasise is, the motion that has been brought by Hon. Bajila should also expose what we are lacking as a nation when it comes to accessing better policy. As I said, I would not want to support this motion to address the problem that is being faced by people yet the very same problem is being faced by other departments in Government ministries. So, I would want a wholesome solution. So, the point that I am trying to make now is, we need certain policies to be enacted and developed so that we allow for

the whole-of-Government approach in terms of dealing with issues of such nature.

For instance, we have got a lot of data collection centres in our Government ministries but these data collection centres do not communicate to each other because as a nation, we made sure that we do not allow general citizens and even institutions to have that interoperability when it comes to the access and utilisation of public data. So, there are certain rules that need to be put in place first before we start to talk about having such kind of interventions.

Lastly, the point that I also want to drive home is, in IT we say, G-I-G-O, that is garbage in, garbage out. The problem that we have if we are to implement artificial intelligence is, it is simply a data-hungry animal. It is something that operates based on the data that it would have been fed. So, what we need first if we are to say maybe we want to implement artificial intelligence around these areas, we need to be very serious and come up with measures where we clean the data that we currently have because the biases are already embedded in the data that we have at the moment. If you are to wake up and say let us have artificial intelligence solutions, what it simply

means is, the artificial intelligence solution will simply learn the biases that is already left in this data that we have. So, we now need policies that allow us to start to clean data in a way that when our AI algorithms consume that data, they come up with unbiased outputs. We also need to make sure that when we implement these AI algorithms... – [HON. MEMBERS: *Inaudible interjection.*] -

THE TEMPORARY SPEAKER: Order, order! Hon. Bajila, you can lower your voice so that Hon. Chigumbu can be heard in considerable silence.

HON. CHIGUMBU: The point that I was trying to make is that we need to come up with policies that are against the issue of how we collect data in a way that the data is palatable with the AI algorithms and gives us outputs that are unbiased. Currently, we have data that is already laced with a lot of biases and even if we are to use that for our AI algorithms, we will still have the same problem. So, we also need to address that first.

To conclude, I would say the motion that has been brought by Hon. Bajila is a very good motion, but this should not only point us to a software intervention, but it must also point us to a cultural shift. It

must point us to sit down as a nation and how to run our things? Do we have to be partisan in every facet of society whereby you have to belong to a certain political party for you to be enrolled in a certain institution or you have to know a certain person from a higher place for you to increase your chances of being enrolled in a certain institution? We must have a whole-of-Government approach to this problem. I submit.

HON. MAKOPE: Thank you Mr. Speaker for giving me this opportunity to add my voice to the motion raised by Hon. Bajila and seconded by Hon. Hamauswa. The motion is very important. I really support this motion and I fully associate myself with the comparing arguments advanced by the mover. The prayers are very clear but what is being proposed is not a novel concept but a logical progression of a direction that our Government has already been taking. We have seen our esteemed Government led by His Excellency Dr. E. D. Mnangagwa embracing this digital artificial intelligence. It is well enshrined in our NDS2, again recently, we have witnessed the launch of Artificial Intelligence Strategy 2026 to 2030. It was done here at this building and that is part of the evidence that

our Government is already taking position and embracing this noble idea the Second Republic, the Hon. Speaker has already in fact demonstrated commitment to artificial intelligence as an enabler for efficiency, transparency, accountability, public service delivery, particularly in critical sectors such as education and health as it has been mentioned in the prayer of our motion.

Mr. Speaker Sir, the proposal before this House is simply about the implementation and operationalising this already embraced idea. Experiences from other jurisdictions further affirm the practicality of this approach in Estonia, Singapore, China and even the USA. Artificial Intelligence and digital systems are already being utilised in public administration where that digitalisation will remove human error or bias and even improve the efficiency.

Applications are assessed against a uniform, predefined criteria, thereby strengthening transparency, consistency and public confidence in outcomes. Equally important is the issue of efficiency in countries such as India and the United Arab Emirates where they have successfully deployed artificial intelligence-driven systems to manage large volumes of applications in public sector recruitment.

These systems significantly reduce processing time, eliminate administrative bottlenecks and ensure that deserving candidates are identified timely and accurately. For Zimbabwe, where demand for nursing and teacher training places far exceeds available capacity, this presents a practical and necessary solution, particularly in the sorting and the processing of the applicants. I do not want to agree with the emphasis that has been made by other presenters or other debaters that artificial intelligence is the solution to the problem where we have the applicants for nursing and teaching, getting places because they are related to certain individuals; I do not think that is true. When Government embraced this artificial intelligence, it was mainly to make sure that we improve in the efficiency of our work because when it comes to the cultural decadence that has been re-emphasised, I think our Government has already been anchored on the *ubuntu* or *hunhu* that has been supported by the Government watchdogs which we have, like the police. So, whenever we have any challenge or any evidence of corruption in our communities, police is there to investigate.

We also have the commission which is very independent that has already been established, Zimbabwe Anti-Corruption Commission (ZACC). It is there to address such issues, the issues of cultural decadence, I think those can be addressed separately from the artificial intelligence.

The main task of this artificial intelligence on our desk is to make sure that we move with time, we digitalise our operations in the Public Service, in the administration of all Government sectors that need artificial intelligence to make sure that we improve with time. Therefore, this motion does not seek to introduce an unfair concept but rather, to align implementation with the policy and to draw from proven international experiences in order to enhance credibility and efficiency in the recruitment system of our Government entities.

So basically, I want to thank Hon. Bajila by bringing up this issue of artificial intelligence motion but again, I want to applaud our esteemed Government and our visionary leader, His Excellency the President, Dr. E. D. Mnangagwa, for already embracing this important aspect in our governance. We have seen that in the NDS2, in the launch of this artificial intelligence at this building. So, our

Government is already on the right trajectory of embracing artificial intelligence as we move with other nations in the globe. I submit to Mr. Speaker Sir.

HON. KANGAUSARU: Thank you Mr. Speaker Sir and greetings from Hurungwe. I rise to support this motion, the adoption of artificial intelligence assisted system in the recruitment and shortlisting of student nurses and student teachers in Zimbabwe. I support this motion, not by restating its premise but by sharpening its agents and locating it within the broader architecture of governance, public trust and State capacity. At its core, this is not a mere technological proposal but a governance reform proposition. Across modern public administration, recruitment integrity had become a defining metric of state of credibility. While selection systems are trusted, institutions are strengthened where they are doubted, even the most qualified output are viewed with suspicion. What we are therefore confronting is not only inefficiency but a credibility deficiency that risks delegitimisation of entire training pipeline in health and education system.

Evidence from global public sector reforms indicate that digital and AI assisted recruitment systems can reduce administrative processing time by up to 70% while significantly improving consistency in candidate evaluation. Most importantly, such system introduces decision traceability whereby every shortlisting outcome can be audited, reconstructed and justified. That single feature, Mr. Speaker Sir, is transformative. It replaces opacity with accountability. We must also appreciate the microeconomic dimension of this issue. Zimbabwe is a net exporter of skilled labour, particularly in nursing and teaching.

Our professionals are globally competitive. However, if the entry point into this profession is compromised, we risk integrating the very quality that underpins the cooperative advantage. In economic terms, this is a threat to our human capital pipeline. However, countries that have digitalised recruitment such as Estonia, widely recognised for its e-Government systems, have demonstrated that integrity at the point of entry translates into higher long-term institutional performance. Similarly, India's adoption of an AI-assisted

admission system has shown measurable reductions in disputes and appeals because outcomes are perceived as procedurally fair.

Mr. Speaker Sir, there is also a constitutional argument that must be advanced further. However, administrative justice is not only about fairness in outcome, it is about procedural rationality. AI systems, when properly designed, enforce rule-based decision making. They limit arbitrary discretion, which is often the breeding ground for corruption. In that sense, AI becomes not just a tool of efficiency, but an instrument of constitutional compliance.

Mr. Speaker Sir, however, for this House to be taken seriously, we must go beyond endorsement and speak to implementation architecture. First, the pilot proposed in the motion must be accompanied by a clear regulatory sandbox. This allows controlled experimentation whilst safeguarding rights. It ensures that the system is tested, refined and validated before a full-scale deployment.

Secondly, there must be algorithmic governance. This includes; independent audit of AI models, clear documentation of selection criteria, mechanism for appeal and human review. Without this, we

risk replacing human bias with automated bias, which is more dangerous and less visible problem.

Thirdly, data integrity must be prioritised. AI systems are only credible as the data they ingest. This requires integration with a verified national database for academic qualification and identity management. If we digitise a flawed data set, we simply accelerate injustice.

Mr. Speaker Sir, let me also introduce a critical but often overlooked dimension, equity of access. Zimbabwe is a rural majority. An AI-driven recruitment platform must not inadvertently disadvantage applicants with limited digital access. Therefore, parallel access points such as district-level application centres, must be maintained to ensure inclusivity. Technology must not become a new barrier.

What is particularly compelling about this reform is scalability. If successfully implemented, this model can be extended beyond nursing and teaching training and into public service recruitment, university admission, and scholarship allocation systems. In effect,

this motion has the potential to catalyse a broad digital transformation which will merit the best selection across the country.

Mr. Speaker Sir, corruption in recruitment is not sustained by complicity. It is sustained by discretion without accountability. AI, when properly governed, constrains that discretion. It standardises judgement, it records decisions, it exposes anomalies. In doing so, it shifts the system from person-dependent to one that is process-driven. Mr. Speaker Sir, the entire motion already established a factual and legal basis for reform.

What this House must now do is to demonstrate political will because ultimately, technology does not reform systems, but leadership does. This motion is, therefore, an opportunity to restore public confidence, to protect mediocracy, to modernise State functions, and to align Zimbabwe with the global best practice in digital governance. In effect, if we fail to act, we entrench a system where opportunity is negotiated. If we act decisively, we build a system where opportunity is earned. That will be choice before this House. I thank you.

THE TEMPORARY SPEAKER: Thank you Hon.

Kangausaru. I will call upon Hon. Bajila to wind up your motion.

HON. BAJILA: Good afternoon Mr Speaker...

HON. G. K. HLATYWAYO: Point of order!

THE TEMPORARY SPEAKER: Yes, Hon. Hlatywayo.

HON. G. K. HLATYWAYO: Yes, I want to debate.

THE TEMPORARY SPEAKER: The normal procedure of the House, Hon. Hlatywayo, is that if you want to debate on a certain motion, you inform your Chief Whips because here, I will be having a list of Members that would want to debate on that motion. So, to keep the tidiness, we would love to always follow that so that we do not end up opening up to some sort of clumsiness. You being you, I know that you are a very understanding Hon. Member who will just take a seat right now and then do it in a proper way the next time. I have trust in you.

HON. G. K. HLATYWAYO: I was not going to be long with your indulgence, I will do that next time. I was going to be very fast. If you can just give me five minutes, that would be okay.

THE TEMPORARY SPEAKER: Okay, because you are always loyal, I will give you that indulgence. You may go ahead. So, two minutes you said, right?

HON. G. K. HLATYWAYO: Yes. Thank you very much Mr. Speaker. I rise to support this motion by Hon. Bajila, and supported by Hon. Hamauswa.

Firstly, I wanted to give context because I think context is very key. The use of artificial intelligence-based system in recruitment in a country such as ours, where the propensity for bias and clientelism on the basis of race, economic status, tribe, political affiliation, is novel and a welcome policy measure. There is no doubt that we need to move with the times. We are in the fourth industrial revolution, and artificial intelligence is becoming an integral part of today's life.

Artificial intelligence-based recruitment measures drive efficiency by automating repetitive tasks such as screening thousands of applications.

In a country such as ours where unemployment is high, and where applications tend to be oversubscribed, artificial intelligence-

based recruitment system will significantly reduce the time of sifting through these many applications. In fact, Mr. Speaker, research has shown that artificial intelligence reduces time to hire by up to 75%.

Artificial intelligence ultimately lowers hiring costs through streamlining the hiring process and reducing the administrative workload. Thus, Government can significantly save resources.

Artificial intelligence-based recruitment system enhances candidate quality, where human-based recruitment systems tend to sacrifice meritocracy in favour of patronage and corruption.

Artificial intelligence-based systems enhance candidate quality through precise data-driven matching. Machine learning algorithms analyse applicants' skills and experience against the job requirements to identify the best suitable candidates, therefore, leading to more qualified hires.

Artificial intelligence also enhances diversity in line with the various provisions of our national Constitution to ensure women, people from ethnic minorities, youths, the disabled, among others, are also recruited. By eliminating demographic information, AI removes both implicit and explicit bias. Companies such as Unilever who have

used AI in their recruitment processes have reported a 16% increase in terms of diversity. AI-based recruitment often results in enhanced candidate experience through the use of AI Chatbot with 24/7 interaction responding to applicants in real time, thus keeping the applicants engaged. We know how lack of responsiveness has been a big challenge in many of our Government departments and therefore, the prayer by this particular motion is timely because it will enhance responsiveness. By adopting artificial intelligence based recruitment systems, transparency will be enhanced and this will rebuild public trust in Government recruitment processes. This motion is transformative Mr. Speaker Sir and we must embrace it. I fully support this motion. I so submit.

THE TEMPORARY SPEAKER: Thank you very much Hon. Hlatywayo. I am glad you kept your word and you kept it short and precise. That is a good spirit.

HON. BAJILA: Good afternoon Mr. Speaker. Thank you so much for giving me this opportunity. I really want to express so much gratitude to members for the debate that they have done on this motion, which shows that as a nation, we are interested in moving

forward together in bringing artificial intelligence to the development of our human capital. With those words, Mr. Speaker, I move that the House adopts the motion.

Motion put and agreed to.

MOTION

BUSINESS OF THE HOUSE

HON. KAMBUZUMA: Good evening Mr. Speaker. I move that Order of the Day, Number 20 be stood over until Order of the Day Number 21 is disposed of.

HON. NYANDORO: I second.

Motion put and agreed to.

ANNOUNCEMENTS BY THE TEMPORARY SPEAKER

NON ADVERSE REPORT RECEIVED FROM THE PARLIAMENTARY LEGAL COMMITTEE

THE TEMPORARY SPEAKER: Before I give Hon. Matewu the floor, Hon. Members, I have to inform the House that I have received a non-adverse report from the Parliamentary Legal Committee on the Tourism Bill [H. B. 7A, 2025].

HOUSE DECORUM

THE TEMPORARY SPEAKER: I have another announcement pertaining to the House Decorum. This will apply mostly to our male Members of Parliament. If you remember, we spoke about attire the other time when the Hon. Speaker of this House asked me to convey a message to you. Today, I again will repeat the same message on attire. It must be noted Hon. Members, that when you put on these presidential shirts, as much as you know that they are not in our Standing Orders, the Hon. Speaker was good enough to indulge us. So, let us make sure that we button up to the top button. That is what you call formal. We do not want to see people's chests, whether they are hairy or not. We want formal dressing. So, every Member of Parliament must make sure that they button up to the last button. If you do not do that, next time we will ask you to leave the House to go and dress properly. You can find under our Standing Order Number 80 (1) to (5) which will guide you accordingly. Thank you.

MOTION

REPORT OF THE PUBLIC ACCOUNTS COMMITTEE ON THE
AUDITED FINANCIAL STATEMENTS FOR THE NATIONAL
HANDLING SERVICES (NHS) FOR THE YEAR 2023

HON. MATEWU: I move the motion standing in my name that this House considers and adopts the Report of the Public Accounts Committee on the audited Financial Statements for the National Handling Services (NHS) in the Auditor General's Report on State-owned Enterprises for the year ended 31 December 2023.

HON. MABURUTSE: I second.

HON. MATEWU: Thank you Mr. Speaker. I rise to give the Public Accounts Committee report on the audited financial statements for the National Handling Services in the Auditor General's report on State-owned enterprises and parastatals for the year ended 31 December 2023.

1.0 INTRODUCTION

1.1 Section 299 (a) of the Constitution of Zimbabwe provides that Parliament must monitor and oversee expenditure by the State and all Commissions and institutions and agencies of Government at every level, including statutory bodies, Government-controlled

entities, provincial and metropolitan councils and local authorities.

In line with that, the Public Accounts Committee analysed the National Handling Services (NHS) financial statements in light of the findings of the Auditor General on the State-owned and Parastatals Accounts for the year ended December 31, 2023. This report highlights PAC's findings, observations and recommendations to address the audit issues identified.

2.0 OBJECTIVES OF THE INQUIRY

The key objectives of the enquiry were:

- i. To scrutinise issues raised in the Auditor General's Report;
- ii. To assess the status of implementation of recommendations made by the Auditor General and challenges faced by the National Handling Services in doing so; and
- iii. To proffer recommendations to address the issues raised in the Auditor General's Report.

3.0 METHODOLOGY

3.1 The Committee conducted an oral evidence session with the officials from the National Handling Services (NHS);

3.2 The Committee held a workshop on the analysis of the Auditor General's Reports for the financial year ended from 14 to 17 March 2025 at the Rainbow Hotel in Bulawayo.

4.0 COMMITTEE FINDINGS

4.1 ACCOUNTING FOR SUBSIDIARY- NHS CC NAMIBIA

The Auditor-General noted that the company did not consolidate the financial statements of its subsidiary based in Namibia (NHS CC Namibia Walvis Bay) since 2019. No financial information was availed for audit pertaining to the subsidiary.

4.1.1 The Acting CEO, M.r Rambakudzibwa, submitted that the company did not necessarily face challenges in obtaining the financial information pertaining to NHS. The financial statements could not be consolidated as the subsidiary financials had not been audited. He buttressed that their auditors, with the assistance of the Auditor General's Office, were appointed after the 2022 year end to audit all the years from 2019.

4.1.2 The Committee was informed that the consolidation for all the years from 2019 to 2023 was being done. The audit for 2023 was

now in its final stages and they expected it to be completed by the time they convened their AGM in mid-December 2024.

COMMITTEE OBSERVATIONS

1. The Committee noted with concern that the failure to consolidate financial statements for a period of five years constituted a serious breach of public financial reporting standards.
2. It observed that the lack of effective oversight over foreign subsidiaries creates significant financial risks.
3. The Committee also observed that delays in completing audits compromise the accuracy of consolidated financial statements.

COMMITTEE RECOMMENDATIONS

1. National Handling should complete all pending consolidations by 30 September 2026 and submit to the Committee.
2. National Handling Services should henceforth implement quarterly financial reporting requirements for all its subsidiaries.
3. National Handling Services should establish clear accountability measures for subsidiary financial management by 30 June 2026

4.2 UTILISATION OF THE SAP SYSTEM

The Auditor-General noted that the company did not fully utilise modules in the SAP system after years of its implementation. As a result, inventory and the asset register were maintained on excel.

4.2 .1 The Committee was informed that the company maintained stocks in excel up to the year ending December 31, 2023.

Maintenance of stocks in SAP started in the 2024 and the stocks were now being maintained. The Acting CEO further submitted that to ensure that staff members were equipped to use the SAP system effectively, they were trained by a certified consultant for basic SAP operations. Plans were underway to train SAP users and this had been slated for 2025.

4.2.2 The Committee was informed that the Financial Accounting (FA) and Materials Management (MM) modules were currently being used optimally. Additionally, the Controlling (CO) module had been onboarded and was being partially utilised, with full implementation expected in 2025.

COMMITTEE OBSERVATIONS

1. The Committee noted with concern that the continued use of Excel, despite significant investment in the SAP system, represents poor utilisation of public resources.
2. It was further observed that the incomplete implementation of the system had exposed the organisation to internal control risks.
3. Additionally, the Committee highlighted that delayed staff training hindered full adoption of the system.

COMMITTEE RECOMMENDATIONS

1. The National Handling Services should complete full implementation of the SAP system by 30 September 2026 and mandate all departments to immediately migrate from Excel to the SAP platform.
2. National Handling Services should conduct monthly progress reviews on system utilisation.
3. National Handling Services should allocate a budget for ongoing staff training and system upgrades by 31 December 2026.
4. National Handling Services should complete all pending consolidations and submit them to the Committee by 31 July

2026. The consolidation must comply with Section 49 (2) (c) of the Public Finance Management Act.

4.3 CLEARING ACCOUNTS RECONCILIATIONS

The Auditor-General noted that the company's internal controls over cash were not adequate. As a result, reconciliations of the cash sales receivable control account were not done as at year end and a balance of ZWL\$263.8 million was not reconciled to the relevant receivables accounts.

4.3.1 The Acting CEO submitted that the ZWL263.8 million balance in accounts receivables was reconciled and cleared in year ending December 31, 2023. The reconciliations for these balances were now being performed daily. The company employed station cashiers and deployed them at all the stations to perform receivables reconciliations at source.

COMMITTEE OBSERVATIONS

The Committee observed that:

1. The unreconciled amount indicates serious control deficiencies.
2. Daily reconciliations, while improved, remain reactive rather than preventive.

3. Cash management systems require modernisation.

COMMITTEE RECOMMENDATIONS

The Committee recommends that the National Handling Services should:

1. Implement automated reconciliation systems by 31 December 2026.
2. Conduct surprise cash audits quarterly.
3. Strengthen supervision of cash handling staff.
4. Develop clear escalation procedures for reconciliation discrepancies by 30 September 2026.

5.0 CONCLUSION

5.1 The Committee acknowledges NHS's efforts to address audit findings but emphasizes the need for urgent, comprehensive reforms. The organisation must prioritise financial discipline, system modernisation, and accountability. Progress on these recommendations should be reported to Parliament quarterly through the Portfolio Committee on Transport when submitting quarterly report.

THE TEMPORARY SPEAKER: Order, order!

HON. MABURUTSE: Thank you Mr. Speaker. I rise to second the report of the Public Accounts Committee on the Audited Financial Statement for the National Handling Services in the Auditor-General's Report on State-Owned Enterprises and Parastatals for the year ended 31 December 2023, presented by the Chairperson of the Committee, Hon. Matewu.

The report before us lays bare serious financial management deficiencies at National Handling Services, a key State-owned enterprise. I will highlight the principal findings and observations and I urge all Hon. Members to support the recommendation as the necessary step towards restoring fiscal discipline and accountability.

Mr. Speaker, allow me to begin with the matter of the subsidiary in Namibia. The Auditor-General noted that the company failed to consolidate the financial statements of its subsidiary, NHS CC Namibia, Walvis Bay since 2019. For five years, no financial information was available for auditing. The Acting CEO submitted that consolidation was ongoing and expected to be finalised by mid-December 2024 and the Committee observed that this failure

constituted a serious breach of public financing reporting standards and created significant financial risks.

To resolve this, the Committee recommended that National Handling Services complete all pending consolidations by 30 September 2026, implement quarterly financial reporting for all subsidiaries, and establish clear accountability measures for subsidiary financial management by 30 June 2026.

The second area of concern is the utilisation of the SAP system. The Auditor-General found that years after its implementation, the company had not fully utilised the system's modules, resulting in an error and the asset register being maintained on Excel. The Committee was informed that SAP stock maintenance started in 2024 and that staff training was planned for 2025. The Committee observed that the continued use of Excel, despite significant investment in the SAP system, represents poor utilisation of public resources. It exposes the organisation to internal control risks.

As a remedy, the Committee recommends full implementation of the SAP system by 30 September 2026, with a mandate for full departments to migrate from Excel, monthly progress reviews, and

allocation of a budget for ongoing staff training and system upgrades by 31 December 2026.

Mr. Speaker, the third area relates to clearing accounts reconciliation. The Committee observed that unreconciled amounts indicate serious control deficiencies, and that daily reconciliation remains reactive rather than preventive. To address this, the Committee recommended that National Handling Services implement automated reconciliation by 31 December 2026, conduct surprise cash audits quarterly, strengthen supervision of cash handling staff, and develop clear escalation procedures for reconciliation discrepancies by 30 September 2026.

The Committee's report does not diminish the importance of National Handling Services. On the contrary, it affirms its critical role in our aviation and logistics infrastructure. The challenges identified relating to the subsidiary oversight, system underutilisation and cash reconciliation are interconnected but solvable. With disciplined implementation of the Committee's recommendations, strengthened oversight and a commitment to transparency, National Handling

Services can be repositioned to fulfil mandates effectively and accountably. I thank you.

HON. KAMBUZUMA: I move that the debate do now adjourn.

HON. NYANDORO: I second.

Motion put and agreed to.

Debate to resume: Tuesday, 7th April, 2026.

On the motion of **HON. KAMBUZUMA** *seconded by* **HON.**

NYANDORO, *the House adjourned at a Minute to Five o'clock p.m. until Tuesday, 7th April, 2026.*